By **RAJ CHENGAPPA** in Colombo

These days, the famed Galle Face in Colombo, lapped by the waves of the Indian Ocean, wears a deceptive calm. Hordes of families throng the beachfront playing ball games and snacking on fried fish peddled by eateries. Just two years ago, in July 2022, it was packed with angry supporters of the *aragalaya* (Sinhala for 'The Struggle'), who mounted a massive protest against the ruling dispensation headed by the Rajapaksa brothers for the economic hardships they had to endure. These included inflation, which had soared to over 100 per cent, a critical shortage of fuel for motor vehicles and a food and fertilisers crisis that pushed Sri Lanka to the brink of a shocking economic collapse. Both Mahinda, who was prime minister, and his younger brother Gotabaya, who was president, had to resign and flee in a hurry as irate mobs stormed into their residential compounds.

Since then, the situation has stabilised under the steadying hand of President Ranil Wickremesinghe, who was forced to take tough measures, including borrowing $2.9 billion from the International Monetary Fund (IMF)—and helped by generous funding from India of over $4 billion—to stem the economic meltdown. But India's southern neighbour could still easily slide over the economic edge. That's why the upcoming presidential elections on September 21 will be another turning point in Sri Lanka's troubled history. A clear verdict may be the last good chance for the island nation to redeem itself.

Wickremesinghe threw his hat into the ring for the presidential contest along with two dozen others. But the political arena is dominated by opportunistic alliances that have shifting loyalties and are popularly termed "jumping frogs". The president himself is in an anomalous position. He heads the United National Party (UNP), but his faction was reduced to a rump in the 2020 prime ministerial elections, with party archrival Sajith Premadasa forming a political alliance called the Samagi Jana Balawegaya (SJB). He walked away with the majority of UNP members, apart from tying up with smaller parties. In a quirk of fate, Wickremesinghe, who lost his seat in the parliamentary election but became the sole UNP MP under the proportional representation quota, took over as president in 2022 with the backing of the Rajapaksa brothers, who controlled the ruling Sri Lanka Podujana Perumana (SLPP). The SLPP had won both the 2020 parliamentary and the 2019 presidential polls with handsome majorities. But the Rajapaksas frittered away the mandate by making serious economic mistakes—reducing taxes for the rich that saw government revenues drop and the overnight banning of chemical fertilisers that impacted agricultural productivity being the most egregious—even as Covid reduced Lanka's tourism sector to rubble and remittances from expats dried up.

Wickremesinghe, who has been PM six times, hopes to win his first-ever presidential election on the back of his performance in righting the economy through raising indirect taxes to meet IMF stipulations and launching bold economic reforms and tight fiscal policies. Seen as a wily operator, Wickremesinghe is standing as an independent candidate and promises stability and economic growth. "This is a make or break election," Wickremesinghe tells INDIA TODAY. "It will decide the future of Sri Lanka. Whether people will be better off or if the whole thing comes apart and we go back to a situation like 2022 or even worse." He hopes for support from both sides of the divide: from his own UNP members and a majority of SLPP MPs, whom his party fought against in 2020, but who now back him as their best bet, with the prominent Rajapaksa brothers out of the picture.

It's a tripolar contest between Wickremesinghe, Premadasa and Dissanayake. Key issues are corruption, cost of living, stability and national unity

But, in a move to prevent the Rajapaksa family from going into political oblivion, Namal, Mahinda's 38-year-old son, has decided to contest under the SLPP flag. This may cut more into Wickremesinghe's vote and keep the Rajapaksas in the running for the parliamentary election that is likely to follow. About not backing Wickremesinghe, Sagara Kariyawasam, SLPP general secretary, says, "The president believes in a neo-liberal economy, but we want a nationalist economy and if we supported him, we had to reach a middle ground. Instead, he took a majority of the members behind our back, but we are confident he will not able to take our support base."

However, Wickremesinghe, 75, faces his toughest competition from two candidates who are in their mid-fifties. One is his erstwhile UNP ally, the suave Sajith Premadasa, 57, a London School of Economics graduate and son of the slain former president, R. Premadasa. He heads a powerful alliance of over 30 parties from across the political spectrum, including the Tamil minority. The other is Anura Kumara Dissanayake, 55, who heads both the Marxist Janata Vimukhti Peramuna (JVP) and the National Peoples Power (NPP) alliance. Both Premadasa and Dissanayake are fighting on